“Capital’s Crisis Air Hints at Development on Cuba; Kennedy TV Talk Is Likely,” read a huge headline on the front page of the *New York Times* for October 22. An article titled “Top Aides Confer. U.S. Forces Maneuver off Puerto Rico—Link Is Denied,” filed the previous day, began by stating, “There was an air of crisis in the capital tonight.” According to the article, whose author was not identified, Kennedy’s return to the White House allegedly for health reasons had spurred feverish activity in Washington. “But the speculation in Washington was that there had been a new development on Cuba that could not be disclosed at this point,” continued the anonymous author. He or she expected Kennedy to make a radio and television address “in the next day or two.” An announcement of the address came in a radio broadcast on the morning of October 22. It was scheduled for 7:00 that evening. For reporters and the public at large, there was nothing to do but wait.[2]

Today’s news in Washington and New York became tomorrow’s news in Moscow. On the morning of October 23 the country’s leading newspaper, *Pravda*, appeared with a headline written the previous night: “The Ruling Circles of the USA Are Playing with Fire.” The Soviet reporter recounted an article that had appeared the previous day in the *New York Herald Tribune*. It had all the hallmarks of similar reports in that day’s American newspapers: Kennedy had interrupted his tour of the country; lights were on in Washington offices late into Sunday night; and naval exercises were underway in the Caribbean. *Pravda* also featured a United Press International piece whose author wrote that a conference of commanding officers of the naval exercises had been canceled, and that journalists were not allowed on ships heading toward Cuba.[3]

No nuclear missiles were mentioned in the American or Soviet reports, but those in the know at the Kremlin assumed that the crisis was about them. “They have probably discovered our missiles,” a disturbed Nikita Khrushchev told his son Sergei when he received a report about Kennedy’s forthcoming address. It was the evening of October 22 in Moscow, and Khrushchev was at home in his apartment in the Lenin (now Vorobiev) Hills. He immediately summoned the members of the party Presidium to the Kremlin. Anastas Mikoyan, the most vocal opponent of the deployment of nuclear weapons in Cuba, received the news at his country house near